

## 5.6.1 Pedagogy for Social Science

Social Science is often taught as a fixed set of facts without an understanding of how interpretations play a role in its construction. This has pushed students towards memorising facts and figures from a textbook, which is not an actual learning of Social Science. A Social Science classroom must be participatory and interactive in nature. It is only when students are allowed to immerse themselves in the process of Social Science thinking that they learn the subject better.

### 5.6.1.1 Pedagogical Considerations

The following pedagogical considerations should be kept in mind while planning for Social Science classes:

- a. **Classroom transactions should help students engage with the method of doing Social Science** so that learners can appreciate the methods for knowledge creation in Social Science. For instance, students may be encouraged to notice patterns in the distribution of different forms of government, such as democracies, monarchies, and dictatorships across the globe and propose reasons (historical, geographical, socio-political, and economic) for the existence of those patterns.
- b. **Classroom teaching should inculcate an awareness and appreciation of normative concerns.** Students should be given opportunities to reflect on various social and environmental issues in their own environment. This should lead to thinking and discussing of meaningful responses to these challenges.
- c. **Multidisciplinary thinking should be encouraged and supported** to ensure that students develop a holistic and integrated understanding of concepts as they appear in society. Any event in history needs to be interpreted in the socio-political or economic contexts of its origin; any geographical phenomena should be evaluated from its impact on space and human lives and its influence on the economy and society. Similarly, any economic concept needs to be understood from its historical and socio-political contexts.
- d. **A Social Science classroom should be a place for contesting ideas, debating, and arguing with empathy and care.** Students must be encouraged to share their diverse experiences and reasoning without the fear of being judged or ridiculed. The Teacher must refrain from imposing their own beliefs and biases on the students and should train students towards looking at one issue from several viewpoints. The entire pedagogy in a Social Science classroom should be an attempt to reveal newer dimensions of social reality and work towards creating self-awareness and introspection among Teachers and students.
- e. **Facts and concepts in Social Science should be made relevant to the students' contexts and experiences.** Such sharing and interactions must be respectful of the cultural and socio-economic differences and multiple perspectives among students.
- f. **Concepts in Social Science need to be clarified with adequate depth and rigour:** In a Social Science classroom, adequate time and attention should be given to concept formation and clarity. For example, students need to understand the processes of weathering and erosion to see their impact on topography and human civilisation; they must engage with the meaning of different types of sources of evidence to frame meaningful interpretations of historical events; and develop a comprehensive understanding of concepts of plurality and

democracy to appreciate the values enshrined in the Constitution and those stressed upon in NEP 2020. The overall classroom environment should encourage academic rigour in acquiring knowledge.

- g. The opportunity to engage with various social-political and environmental matters** through investigating and interpreting multiple sources of evidence available, such as documentaries, literature (books, local stories, travelogues), newspaper reports, and relevant films should be undertaken. Selecting materials that are relatable to students and help in developing curiosity about the discipline should be prioritised. At the same time, care should be taken to ensure that materials are taken from reliable sources of information and do not depict biases for or against a particular thought, philosophy, group, or people.
- h. Authentic tasks/performance-based tasks, such as project-based learning activities and assignments, should be incorporated** to give learners an opportunity to develop different types of capacities such as surveying, data analysis, problem solving, and collaborative skills to validate and investigate their assumptions and beliefs.

### 5.6.1.2 Pedagogical Strategies

To design lessons around these considerations, there are many strategies that Teachers can deploy. Illustratively:

- a. Inquiry:** Inquiry-based methods help students understand how social scientists generate knowledge. For instance, students can make and test hypotheses about factors that influence migration in their locality or region, the genesis of various settlement patterns in their region, why specific types of occupations are more prevalent in specific regions, and so on.
- b. Issues-based learning:** Issues-based learning can be a conducive tool for acquainting students with various aspects of social realities, integrating perspectives from different disciplines in investigating the causes of problems, and thinking about relevant social action. As a subject addressing normative concerns, it is also vital that students learn much of the Social Science content by engaging with real issues in their immediate/related context. For instance, students may consider the problem of drinking water shortage in their area, which may involve engaging with questions such as – What are the available sources of water? How does water consumption differ across different parts of the region/locality? Are there wastages that can be avoided? How is water being made accessible to all sections of society? Is there unequal distribution? What steps are being taken to purify water? How is it being made available to the poorer sections of society?
- c. Conversations, discussions, and debates:** Conversations are extremely vital in a Social Science classroom. These conversations should lead to focussed discussions on concepts, ideas, belief systems, and value claims. Sometimes these discussions may turn into debates in the classroom. It is important to encourage such debates, as it provides students with the opportunity to put forth their perspectives, resolve conflicts, iron out contradictory ideas, and learn from each other. However, care must be taken that such discussions and debates do not hurt the sentiments of any social group. Some common topics for discussion could be on climate change, diversity in clothing and types of food as per historical and geographical reasons and practising democratic processes in schools.

- d. Role plays and simulations:** Role plays and simulations may help students explore decision-making processes and find means for conflict resolution. For instance, role plays of the Gram Panchayat/Corporation may be used as a vehicle to explain the functioning of a democratic institution.
- e. Community service and field excursions:** Community service is yet another engaging strategy in a Social Science classroom. It not only involves concrete experiences for learning concepts from the curriculum, but also enables students to develop the desired values. Students may take up various projects to work with local government agencies to acquire first-hand experience of issues and work with people in need. Similarly, field excursions are meaningful ways of engaging with the content, e.g., nature walks, heritage walks, food walks, and visits to police stations, museums, post offices, planetariums, and government and digital archives.
- f. Reflective essays:** Students can write reflective essays on various topics related to the curriculum. These essays can also be used by Teachers to assess the extent to which students have learnt the desired concepts and skills. For instance, a reflective essay topic could be, 'How will dams transform agricultural productivity in India?', 'What are the issues and opportunities of linking rivers?', 'What sustainable agricultural strategies could a region adopt if its main river turns seasonal or dries up?', or 'Is waste management and disposal the sole responsibility of municipalities and other government agencies?'
- g. Project work:** Effective Social Science teaching happens when students collaborate for a project or a specific task. These could be conducting surveys and interviews (e.g., household surveys, interviews with stakeholders of the society such as village sarpanch), drawing a map of their classroom, investigating historical sources in their region, tabulating the types of *bazaars*/markets. Such projects should be collaboratively designed along with students with sufficient time given to collect data, analyse it, and present it in the classrooms.
- h. Some specific opportunities for projects to create models and artefacts:** Students should be given opportunities where they can apply their knowledge to create models and artefacts. These could be in the form of poster-making, collections (old coins, newspapers, stamps, types of rocks, leaves, flowers, photographs, pamphlets), models (2-dimensional or 3-dimensional, e.g., monuments, volcanoes, still scenes), videos of rallies/*haat bazaars*/book fairs/any social events in their surroundings.

### 5.5.1 Principles of Content Selection

The content selection in Social Science must fulfil the Curricular Goals, account for the nature of knowledge, and should systematically address the current challenges of Social Science teaching and learning.

These considerations inform the principles below, which should be used while selecting the content:

- a. **Content must be adequate to develop relevant knowledge and capacities:** The topics chosen should together be able to help achieve the relevant knowledge and capacity goals of the curriculum. At the same time, there must not be **content overload**, which has been a significant cause of ineffective Social Science teaching and learning. This balance of having appropriate amount of content is one of the key challenges in developing Social Science curricula.
- b. **Content must be based on verified evidence and narratives:** A good Social Science study of any concept or event requires engaging with evidence from a range of sources, references, and consequent interpretations and narratives. The range of what is admissible evidence for Social Sciences will draw from the socio-cultural contexts of India and from multiple pieces of evidence verified rigorously from various sources; it should give a sampling of differing interpretations or narratives (if justified by verified evidence) of a single event or phenomenon. For example, good understanding of the Gandhian philosophy of non-violence should be accomplished through the readings of multiple writers, or the usefulness and limits of markets should be seen from varied perspectives.
- c. **Content must be interdisciplinary in approach:** Social Science, by its very nature, is an interdisciplinary subject. The discipline-wise division of History, Geography, Political Science, and Economics, and others such as Anthropology, Philosophy, Psychology, and Sociology cannot be seen as separate areas in isolation. None of these disciplines can be

taught (or understood) without referring to another. For example, the concept of India's cultural unity in diversity cannot be taught without introducing the student to India's geographical unity in diversity, or to its shared philosophical and political concepts. Students should learn to investigate a concept from multi-dimensional and cross-disciplinary perspectives to develop an expansive view.

- d. **Concepts must be built from the simple to the complex:** The content in Social Science should be organised, with simpler concepts leading to more complex ones, enabling the construction of whole meaning with building blocks. This must be done progressively, including by considering the developmental trajectory of cognitive capacities of students. For example, for teaching historical inquiry in the Middle Stage, the content would first focus on the identification and differentiation of sources of information or evidence, taking a local case study as starting point where possible. As a second step, students should interpret the evidence to draw meaning out of it. Third, where possible, they should attempt to collect and analyse evidence from multiple sources for a single event, engaging in discussions if such evidence at times appear to point to differing conclusions. And finally, where possible, they should do a comparative analysis between two or more similar events based on findings made through multiple sources. Such an exercise can be done at a basic level, to familiarise the student with the methodology in a light way.
- e. **Content to progress from local to global:** As much as possible, conceptual understanding should start from the local context. For example, understanding geography is best achieved by first engaging with local terrain (streams, lowlands, uplands) in the locality, and then moving to features of the regional and national terrains. The same method is applicable to History and to other areas of Social Science.
- f. **Content to include real and diverse experiences of people:** As Social Science deals with human beings and society, the study is incomplete with just theories and concepts. Without references to the real-world experiences of people, past or present, concepts do not 'come to life'. For example, the concept of an uprising against colonial rule cannot be grasped without an appreciation for the courage of the people through a few first-hand accounts or testimonies; or discrimination and efforts to address it cannot be taught without introducing the students to accounts of people who have faced it personally and those who have been helped by measures taken at various levels. Real experiential accounts also help develop values and dispositions such as empathy, sensitivity, and pride in our heritage.
- g. **Content must enable development of capacities:** Social Science aims at developing decision-making and problem-solving capacities in the social context to enhance social, cultural, and environmental harmony, which involves the interpretation of facts, relying on evidence, and connecting concepts to form rational and forward-looking opinions. The content in Social Science should not merely present facts but also help develop these capacities and enable inference, analysis, and a grasp of the complex, integrated nature of human life and society while being open to other perspectives.
- h. **Content must enable the development of values and dispositions:** The choice of content in Social Science and its tone of presentation should have both implicit and explicit influence on the values and dispositions of students. While the overall content must be valid and adequately representative of a range of perspectives, it should also be deeply informed by the values and dispositions that it will foster.